SIOUX BATTLE DRESS

A raiding party of Sioux and other Plains Indian warriors was traditionally equipped with bows and arrows, shields, lances, clubs, and scalping knives. In the 19th century Sioux weaponry evolved under the influence of contact with Euro-American settlers and traders. Metal blades or tips replaced stone or bone on traditional weapons, while industrially produced implements were bought from traders and customized with decorative motifs. The Sioux also adopted firearms, although they were more effective fighters with the bow and arrow. Although the superior weaponry of European settlers made it hard for the Native Americans to take on the intruders in open battle, Indian weapons were effective in low-level guerrilla warfare.

> "WHOSE VOICE WAS FIRST SOUNDED ON THIS LAND? THE VOICE OF THE RED PEOPLE WHO HAD BUT BOWS AND ARROWS."
>
> **RED CLOUD** OGALA SIOUX (1822–1909), ON THE ENCROACHMENT OF THE WHITE MAN

Headdress
The feathered headdress is often considered to be a significant feature of Native American dress in the 19th century, and is certainly the most recognizable. However, in reality, the headdress was worn (outside of tribal rituals) only by the Sioux tribes of the Midwestern plains. An eagle-feathered war bonnet such as this would have been the mark of an experienced and respected warrior.

Headband

Fur tassels

Quiver and bowcase
Plains Indians, who always travelled on horseback when fighting and hunting, used a combined bowcase and quiver to carry their bow and arrows. Made of animal hide, it was slung across the rider's back, suspended on a strap. Arrows were traditionally tipped with stone, but following contact with Europeans, iron was increasingly used instead.

Bow of twisted buffalo sinew

Plains warrior carried about 20 arrows in his quiver

Wooden bow reinforced with sinew

Heavy stone end was used to devastating effect on enemy warriors